



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

THE REPORT found Los Angeles County had no clear process for who should issue evacuation orders.

Sorting fact from fear on Tylenol

Acetaminophen is safest option for pain relief in pregnancy, physicians say.

By CORINNE PURTILL

During this week’s White House news conference in which President Trump named the over-the-counter drug Tylenol as a possible cause of rising autism rates, he did not mince words, urging pregnant women to “fight like hell” not to take it.

But outside those remarks in the Roosevelt Room — during which Trump himself acknowledged, “I’m not so careful with what I say” — the discussion on the common fever and pain reliever’s role during pregnancy is a lot more nuanced.

What the research actually says

Physicians, researchers on the very studies cited in support of Trump’s position and even other members of the president’s administration are largely united on a few key facts: Untreated fevers in pregnancy pose real risks to the fetus, acetaminophen (Tylenol’s active ingredient) remains the safest medication to treat them and any pregnant person seeking advice on the issue should consult their doctor.

[See Tylenol, A7]

Amazon to settle Prime claims for \$2.5 billion

The agreement comes days into a trial over a suit alleging company tricked customers.

By QUEENIE WONG

Amazon has agreed to pay \$2.5 billion to settle accusations it tricked millions of customers into subscribing to Prime and made it tough for them to cancel.

Under the settlement — one of the largest to come out of a Federal Trade Commission case — Amazon will pay up to \$51 each to eligible customers.

In the lawsuit, first filed by the FTC in 2023, the agency accused Amazon of duping people into auto-

matically renewing their Amazon Prime subscriptions through “manipulative, coercive, or deceptive user-interface designs.” Amazon also made it complicated for people to end their membership, the lawsuit said.

A trial over the lawsuit, filed under the Biden administration, kicked off in Seattle this week. The settlement, announced on Thursday, is the latest example of how the federal government has been trying to rein in the power wielded by Big Tech.

“Today, we are putting billions of dollars back into Americans’ pockets, and making sure Amazon never does this again,” FTC Chairman Andrew Ferguson said in a statement. “The Trump-Vance FTC is committed to

fighting back when companies try to cheat ordinary Americans out of their hard-earned pay.”

Amazon didn’t admit guilt by agreeing to the settlement.

Mark Blafkin, an Amazon spokesperson, said the company and its executives “have always followed the law and this settlement allows us to move forward and focus on innovating for customers.”

“We work incredibly hard to make it clear and simple for customers to both sign up or cancel their Prime membership, and to offer substantial value for our many millions of loyal Prime members around the world,” he said in a statement.

[See Amazon, A12]

U.S. indicts ex-FBI Director Comey

By ERIC TUCKER, ALANNA DURKIN RICHER AND MICHAEL KUNZELMAN

WASHINGTON — James Comey was charged Thursday with lying to Congress in a criminal case filed days after President Trump appeared to urge his attorney general to prosecute the former FBI director and other perceived political enemies.

The indictment makes Comey the first former senior government official involved in one of Trump’s chief grievances, the long-concluded investigation into Russian interference in the



ANDREW HARNIK Associated Press

JAMES COMEY, shown in 2017, has been charged with lying to Congress and obstruction of justice.

No blame cited in late Eaton fire evacuation alerts

Report notes poor communication among officials and chaotic conditions.

By TERRY CASTLEMAN, REBECCA ELLIS AND GRACE TOOHEY

Poor communication, understaffing, a lack of adequate planning and chaotic conditions contributed to a failure to issue timely evacuation orders to parts of Altadena as the deadly Eaton fire raced through the community, according to a long-awaited report released Thursday.

The report did not assign blame to individuals for the botched alerts, but found Los Angeles County had no clear process for who should issue evacuation orders and called for significant reforms. Nineteen people died in the fire, all but one of whom was found in west Altadena, an area that did not get evacuation alerts until hours after the fire threatened the area.

However, the 132-page report seemed to downplay how early the fire threatened west Altadena — despite 911 calls that reported flames and smoke in the area.

Instead, it focused on the fire’s “perfect storm,” officials’ poor preparation and the fact that the satellite-outlined “fire front” hadn’t entered west Altadena until 5 a.m. — nearly two hours after evacuation alerts were issued.

But those alerts came hours after several spot fires were confirmed in the area and well after some fire officials pointed out the area was at risk.

The independent investigation by consulting firm McChrystal Group — released eight months after

Key findings from report

- Officials failed to evacuate west Altadena residents in a timely way.
- Outdated policies led to unclear decision-making.
- The Office of Emergency Management did not have adequate staffing.
- Lack of internet access at fire command post stymied response.

the Los Angeles-area firestorm — was commissioned by the county after The Times revealed that the county failed to issue timely evacuation alerts in west Altadena.

“This McChrystal group report highlights the fact that we are not prepared if,

[See Fire, A8]

A year of mortgage relief for firestorm victims

Newsom signs a bill that bars foreclosure proceedings and takes effect immediately.

By LAURENCE DARMIENTO

Legislation that allows victims of the Jan. 7 firestorms to receive up to a year of mortgage relief was signed by Gov. Gavin Newsom as an urgency measure that takes effect immediately.

Assembly Bill 238 enables borrowers to put a stop to their mortgage payments for up to 12 months with no late fees or penalties, by attesting without documentation that the fires caused a financial hardship.

The relief is extended in 90-day increments that can be extended at the property owner’s request. The law prohibits mortgage servicers from initiating a foreclosure or executing a foreclosure judgment or sale.

“Homeowners rebuilding after a disaster need all the support they can get, including grace in light of this incredible hardship,” Newsom said in a statement after signing the legislation this week. “I look forward to additional conversations with lenders in the coming months about how we can continue to support survivors together.”

The bill, co-sponsored by Assemblymember John Harabedian (D-Pasadena) and Assemblymember Jacqui Irwin (D-Thousand Oaks), whose districts include the Eaton and Palisades fire zones, respectively, provides more generous relief than a voluntary forbearance program Newsom and Harabedian put together in January.

That program provides for 90 days of relief from payments, without accruing late fees or damage to credit scores.

It also offers protections from new foreclosure of eviction actions for at least 60 days. More than 400 financial institutions signed on to the program.

Any relief provided under that program, operated by the Department of Financial Protection and Innovation, would be credited toward the 12-month extension limit established by AB 238.

“For months since the fires, survivors have been forced to make two housing payments: one for their temporary rental accommodation

[See Mortgage, A8]

COLUMN ONE

Snakes as weapons: Case marked state’s last hanging

By Keri Blakinger

Wearing a dapper black suit and an almost triumphant expression, Robert James glanced down at the crowd gathered at the foot of the gallows. It was May 1, 1942, and the red-haired barber from Alabama was about to become the 215th man hanged in California.

His journey to the scaffold wasn’t just strange — it was pure noir, ripped from the pages of a Raymond Chandler novel. There was a dead blond beautician. A philandering husband. A double indemnity life insurance policy. And then there were the murder weapons: diamondback rattlesnakes named Lethal and Lightning.

The courtroom circus that passed for a trial attracted reporters and Hollywood celebrities, each clamoring to peer at the lineup of eccentric witnesses, the array of gruesome crime scene photos, and the pair of live rattlers the state

presented as angry, hissing evidence.

Pandemonium broke out when Lethal wriggled free, slithering around the courtroom until two snake handlers recaptured the errant serpent with a trash can and a wire noose.

“If you made a movie out of this, nobody would believe it,” Michael Fratanтони, the Los Angeles County Sheriff’s Department’s staff historian, told The Times.

But the case stands out for another reason: It was the state’s last hanging execution. And according to Fratanтони, it did not go particularly well, leaving the warden horrified.

By that point the state had already decided to replace the noose with the ostensibly more humane gas chamber, so James’ execution ushered out one era of capital punishment with a harbinger of what has plagued the practice since: It’s surprisingly hard to find a palatable way to kill people.

[See Snakes, A14]



CHRIS CODUTO Getty Images

DODGERS CLAIM NL WEST

It took longer than expected, but L.A. clinched its 12th division title in 13 seasons with an 8-0 win over the Arizona Diamondbacks. **SPORTS, B10**

Budget office calls for cuts

White House is telling agencies to draft mass firing plans ahead of possible government shutdown. **NATION, A6**

Weather

Low clouds, then sun. L.A. Basin: 79/66. **B6**

Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A13**

Dallas shooter targeted agents

Officials say gunman who fired on an ICE facility hated the U.S. government. **NATION, A6**

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